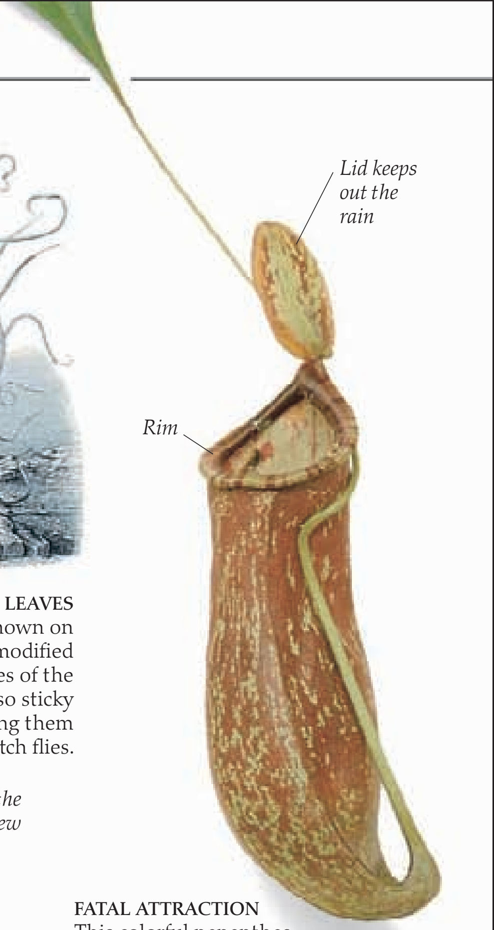
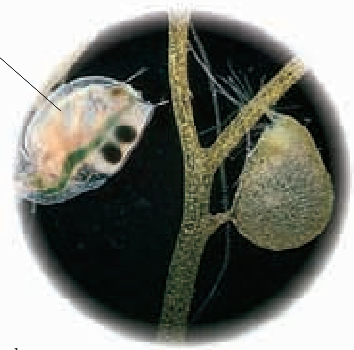
Meat-eaters

Although man-eating plants belong to the world of fiction, there are many plants that eat insects and other small animals. These carnivorous, or meat-eating, plants fall into two groups. Some species, such as the Venus flytrap (pp. 42–43), have active traps, with moving parts that catch their prey. Other species have inactive traps with no moving parts. They simply attract their victims with a scent reminiscent of food, and then catch them on a sticky surface or drown them in a pool of fluid. The victims of carnivorous plants are mostly insects. Once an insect has been caught, it is slowly dissolved by digestive fluids produced by the plant. After many days, all that is left is the insect's exoskeleton—the hard outer casing of the body. The rest of the insect has been absorbed by the plant. Carnivorous plants can make food from sunlight like ordinary plants. The insects they catch are simply used as an extra source of food because they grow in waterlogged ground, where the soil is deficient in nitrates and other essential nutrients.

SPECIALIZED LEAVES
All the animal traps shown on these two pages are modified leaves. The leaves of the Portuguese sundew are so sticky that people used to hang them up indoors to catch flies.



FATAL ATTRACTION
This colorful nepenthes pitcher lures passing insects.



UNDERWATER TRAPS
Bladderworts are water plants that develop traps, in the form of tiny bladders, on their feathery leaves. If a small water animal swims past, the bubblelike bladder snaps open and the animal is sucked inside.

THE STICKY SUNDEWS
The leaves of sundews are covered in hairs that produce droplets of sticky glue. When an insect lands on one of the leaves, it sticks to the hairs, which then fold over, trapping it.

Magnified view of a fly trapped by hairs on a sundew leaf

Cape sundew

LYING IN WAIT
Butterworts have circles of flat, sticky leaves. These plants may not look very threatening, but when an insect lands on a leaf, it becomes glued to the surface and eventually dies. The edges of the leaf very gradually curl inward, and the insect is digested. There are about 50 species of butterwort, most of which grow in marshy places.

Butterwort